

they pass along those payments. In that case, you would still contact your initial lender with any questions.

Why am I getting all this mail about my property after moving in? It looks like a scam—is it?

Here's something that very few people mention: You're going to get a lot of junk mail when you first move in. A *lot*. It's all going to look official, and some letters will ask you to make mysterious payments.

The thing is, your home purchase is public information. Anyone can see who purchased a home and when, and that information is commonly used to scam new homeowners into making petty payments. Some will look like tax, mortgage, or insurance information, and the scammer will ask you to pay a small fee to file something or sign up for something. The fee is so small that some people pay it just in case.

Open all this mail and read it. If it's from your lender—or whoever your lender sells your mortgage to—it's probably legitimate, but you can contact them and ask if you're not sure. If it's a notice that your lender sold your mortgage to XYZ Bank, make sure to verify this information before sending any payments to the new bank. (Heads up: It might not be a real bank.) Your initial lender will also send an email or contact you otherwise about selling your mortgage, so it shouldn't come totally out of the blue.

Long story short, don't send any payments in response to odd mail that you get at your new home. If you're unsure whether something is official, ask your lender or agent for guidance.

What kind of tax benefits will I get as a homeowner?

One benefit we already talked about in Chapter Three relates to appreciation. As an individual homeowner, you can exclude up to \$250,000 in capital gains from the sale of your home, or up to \$500,000 on the sale of your home as a married couple. If you experience any sort of appreciation, you may not have to pay taxes on that gain when you sell your home. There is one catch: You usually must have lived in the property as a primary residence for two or more of the last five years.

Another benefit is the mortgage interest deduction. If you choose to itemize your tax deductions rather than using the standard deduction, you can reduce your taxable income by the amount of money you've paid in